daughters of eminent men, myriad ambitions and clashing desires whirled in dense circles around the mirzas, who were like planets around the sun that was the Padshah, waiting for the inexorable dawn of the next emperor.

Akbar and his sons married women from all the important ethnic groups in Hindustan except the Afghans, with the largest groups being the Persian, Turki, and Rajput families. But where the Padshah's daughters were concerned, no Mughal princess was married to a Rajput, a non-Muslim noble, or a shaikhzada. Akbar's daughters were married to exalted Turki families or to royal princes. Hypergamy was similarly exercised among the Rajput clans, with lower status families looking to marry their daughters into higher status families.

After Akbar, no non-royal groom was ever considered worthy of marrying a Mughal princess, and as the generations evolved, and cousins and uncles were routinely killed during increasingly violent succession struggles, these princesses often remained unmarried, leading to rumours, fuelled by European accounts, that Mughal emperors preferred to keep their daughters for their own perverse pleasure. The French adventurer François Bernier, never one to refrain from the most lurid rumour-mongering, would primly claim that 'it is painful to allude to the rumour of his [Shah Jahan's] unnatural attachment, the justification of which he rested on the decisions of the mullahs. According to them, it would have been unjust to deny the king the privilege of gathering fruit from the tree he himself had planted.'

As for the Rajputs, their links with the Mughal court through marriages and service ensured a corresponding change in their clans and territories. Raja Udai Singh, following the Mughal system, introduced the payment of a peshkash, later known as the hukmnama, owed by noblemen when a jagir lapsed on the death of its jagirdar. Marwar also saw the introduction of an extensive communication network at this time, linking the region with the Mughal Empire. As in other parts of the empire, dak chowkis or post stations were set up along major roads connecting towns and cities and allowed for the very rapid transmission of news, commands, and papers. Monserrate had noted in amazement that the runners along these routes could cover the same distance as a horseman at full speed. 'They practise running in shoes made of lead,' the Jesuit wrote, 'or train themselves by repeatedly lifting their feet and moving their legs till their heels touch their buttocks. When their leaden shoes are removed, they are seen to be magnificent runners, by the help of whose swiftness the King can very